say whether our people grudged them most the nine new hospital tents, which with all the furniture they appropriated, or certain kegs containing not fewer than thirty thousand rounds of musket ammunition'.[71] That ammunition would later be used on the rest of the Kabul army with deadly effect.

The following day the British again found themselves surrounded; but this time in addition their passage forwards was blocked by an immense force of cavalry obstructing their advance on Tezin. After a brief stand-off, Sale agreed to admit to his camp a delegation which arrived under flag of truce. Negotiations were resumed in the Ghilzai camp, from where George MacGregor, the Political Officer attached to the column, reported 'that the chiefs received him with great politeness, and were pleased at the confidence reposed in them by his going to meet them attended only by one suwar [cavalryman]. They appeared to be unanimous, and many in number, mustering 700 followers, who were daily increasing.'[72]

MacGregor eventually agreed to pay the tribe all they asked. 'They are to get the Rs 40,000 the quarrel began about,' reported Lady Sale, 'and they promise to return any property they can find of ours: so that we can leave off where we set out, barring our killed and wounded, expence, loss of ammunition and baggage, and the annoyance of the detention, if not the loss, of all our daks [post].'[73] But it was more serious than Lady Sale realised. Few now believed the negotiations would do more than buy time, while some such as Henry Durand thought it a huge mistake. 'It was a time for action,' he wrote. 'Fighting Bob', he believed, should have been 'striking not talking'.[74] But the payment did allow Sale to send the wounded back to Kabul with an armed escort in order to warn the authorities there of the scale of the uprising, and for the rest of the column to head on down towards Jalalabad at speed. Moreover, as John Magrath, the morose surgeon of the force, wrote, 'I am glad we are to have no more fighting, for everything Sale and Dennie have a hand in is sure to be bungled.'[75]

Ominously, after a two-day lull, the attacks began again. 'The rear guard has been attacked daily,' reported Sale at the end of the week, 'and the bivouack fired at each night.'[76] Each morning, 'as soon as the bugle called in the pickets, numbers of Afghans started up as if by magic from behind every rock, boulder, hillock, bush or tuft of grass within half a mile of the camp, forming a vast semicircle of enemies'.[77] The numbers of Afghans continued to grow. As Lady Sale noted from the cantonment, 'All the forts